Fifteen Things to Pay Attention to When Mom Comes Home From the Hospital

Everyday things to notice and write down in the first weeks, with no diagnosing.

You're watching Mom closely, but you may not be sure what you're watching for. This guide names fifteen everyday things worth noticing and, for each, what to write down.

Notice and record. Don't interpret. What a change means is a question for her doctor, nurse or therapist, and the notes you keep are what make that conversation useful. The areas below are the ones Medicare's discharge checklist and the Family Caregiver Alliance's discharge guide tell families to watch for; the wording about what to write down is ours.

Getting through the day

1 Bathing and washing [1]

NOTICE Whether she bathes on her own, needs things set up, needs a hand, or avoids it.

WRITE DOWN Which of those four it is, and whether it changed since before the hospital.

2 Dressing [1]

NOTICE Buttons, shoes, choosing clothes for the weather, how long it takes.

WRITE DOWN What she manages alone and where she stops.

3 Using the bathroom [1]

NOTICE Getting there in time, managing clothing, cleaning up.

WRITE DOWN Any accidents, with the day and time, and no commentary.

4 Stairs and doorways [1]

NOTICE Whether she uses the stairs, holds the rail, pauses, or avoids rooms she used to use.

WRITE DOWN The rooms and the stairs she still uses, and the ones she doesn't.

Moving around

5 Standing up and sitting down [2]

NOTICE From bed, chair and toilet: what she holds, how long it takes, whether she needs a hand.

WRITE DOWN Each transfer, and the help she uses for it.

6 Walking inside [1]

NOTICE Steadiness, touching furniture as she goes, the walker that is actually used or parked in a corner.

WRITE DOWN How she gets from room to room, and what she uses.

7 Falls and near-falls

NOTICE A fall, a stumble, a grab for the counter.

WRITE DOWN Date, time, where, and what she was doing. Don't decide why.

Eating and drinking

8 Meals [1]

NOTICE Who prepares them, what she eats, whether she skips, how long a meal takes.

WRITE DOWN A typical day's meals and who made them.

9 Swallowing and coughing at meals

NOTICE Coughing or clearing her throat while eating or drinking, food left on one side, long chewing.

WRITE DOWN When it happens and with what. This one goes to the clinician; write it down and tell them.

10 Weight, appetite and thirst

NOTICE A looser watch band, untouched glasses of water, clothes fitting differently.

WRITE DOWN Rough notes with dates. You don't need a scale.

Medications

11 The pills and the list [1]

NOTICE Whether what's in the house matches the written list, who fills the pill box, and any missed or doubled doses.

WRITE DOWN The differences, as facts. Don't change anything; questions go to the prescriber or the pharmacist.

Mind and mood

12 Memory in the moment

NOTICE A question repeated, the time of day lost, a name missed.

WRITE DOWN How often, not what it means.

13 Mood and energy

NOTICE Withdrawn, tearful, irritable, or sleeping during the day.

WRITE DOWN What's different from her usual self, and since when.

14 Night

NOTICE Up at night, confused after dark, wandering.

WRITE DOWN What time and what happened.

People and help

15 Who comes and who doesn't [1]

NOTICE The help that's actually arriving: home health, therapy, neighbors, family. And the hours when nobody is there.

WRITE DOWN A week's worth of who came when, and the gaps.

When a note isn't enough

Anything on this list that is new and sudden, or anything the discharge papers told you to watch for, is a call to the number you were given, not a note for later. Medicare's checklist tells families to ask before discharge which complications to watch for and what to do about them. If you didn't get that answer, call and ask for it.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any of these mean, how serious they are, or what kind of care Mom needs. The care team does that, and they do it better with your notes in front of them.

Ready for the next step?

You've gathered and noticed. The care interview walks you through Mom's situation area by area so nothing important is overlooked, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Your Discharge Planning Checklist (CMS Product No. 11376)
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
3. Agency for Healthcare Research and Quality, Taking Care of Myself: A Guide for When I Leave the Hospital (further reading)